Chapter 1
The Verse of welcome

As he cleans the spilled ale from the white marble floor, Zethan is not focused on his duties. He is far too occupied with the person who is about to be announced into the great hall.
A servant at the royal palace of Veridia, Zethan is an Out Chord—a nobody, invisible to the nobility and the High Chord. He isn't bitter about his status. For an Out Chord, he is remarkably well treated, but a nobody nonetheless.
In a quiet corner of the great hall, he stands leaning against a marble column, one of more than fifty that line the back wall, framing the magnificent thousand-year-old stained-glass windows that seem to stretch on forever. For a brief moment, he forgets where he is and reaches beneath his collar, gently clasping the dull, jagged black stone that hangs around his neck. It feels colder than usual, pulling his attention back to the room just as the choir begins to sing.
The choir is made up entirely of Mid Chord men. As they sing, their voices awaken the dozens of crystal chandeliers suspended twenty feet above the floor. They are not lit by candles, but by magic. If you look closely at the vaulted ceiling of the great hall, you can see ribbons of light flowing along the marble rafters and into the crystal chandeliers. Almost like smoke, the delicate streams of coloured light drift into the crystals, causing them to glow with brilliant intensity.
The members of the choir all wear crystals similar to Zethan's, but much brighter and cleaner. They are prism resonators, acting as amplifiers and specially tuned to the person who wears them. They are extremely rare these days, passed down through families as heirlooms and, as such, dictate a person's standing in society. They are also explicitly linked to a noble family's political power and identity.
As Zethan is not a noble man and is of low standing in society, it is highly unusual for him to have a crystal resonator of any kind, even the seemingly useless one he wears, which appears to grant him no power at all. The nobility callsit a null-core, as it has a null-frequency and zero resonance, shown by the lack of light that usually glows from all resonators when worn. But he wears it as a reminder of his family, whom he has not seen in a long, long time.
He keeps it hidden at all times. If he were to be seen wearing a null-core, he would be telling everyone that he has no power and is totally voiceless and powerless, placing him among the lowest-ranking citizens in society.
Although most Out Chords can cast minor verse without a crystal, using it for small, menial tasks like lifting timber or pushing a heavy stone block by shouting or singing loudly, Zethan can't. His voice produces nothing but raw static when he sings. He can't cast the low-level kinetic energy that regular servants use to sweep and mop the floors.
The choir signals the entrance of the royal families from the other realms. Zethan's eyes lock onto Valerious, the prince from the Summer Realm, as he enters the great hall; tall, with sun-bleached, long blond hair and amazing, glowing amber eyes. His face is a work of art, with chiselled cheeks and a

strong jaw, carrying that aristocratic look that makes it obvious he is part of the elite High Chord.
Their eyes lock from across the hall as he walks towards the royal throne where the King sits, an amazing white, carved marble throne adorned with sumptuous cushions and throws, all in the royal autumn tones of copper brown and embroidered with gold thread and lace. Each royal family of the four realms has their own colours that match the season of the realm they rule. Veridia is a beautiful realm filled with endless forests of copper-leaved trees and gothic buildings adorned with glass lanterns that line the immaculately clean cobble streets. The palace itself is almost entirely made of intricately carved white marble and stained-glass windows, filled with images of the royals from yesteryear.
Valerious fits into the palace very well. He wears an immaculately tailored white and gold suit, reminiscent of the sun-drenched land of Estariel. Around his neck hangs a beautiful crown jewel, a solar ruby necklace that rests against his bare, open-collared chest. It has a bright, glowing aura, like embers in a fire, projecting light upon his face that simply emphasises his beauty.
As they lock eyes, Valerious moves his lips ever so slightly, as if to whisper, but the choir is so loud that no one can possibly hear what he says. Luckily for him, all the nobility are focused on impressing the King, showboating in an attempt to gain favour.
For if he were to be seen using the Murmur in front of the downtrodden, there would be serious consequences. You see, casting the Murmur is technically illegal, as it is the forbidden magic of the ruling dynasties and royal families and is punishable by death. However, the nobility uses it all the time to keep the downtrodden and outcasts in their place. The use of it among the company of other High Chords is largely accepted, as long as no one reveals its use to the lesser people. They want to maintain power and control over the order of their citizens, and it would be political suicide if they were to be seen breaking the rules of the land with no consequences.
This tiny whisper is inaudible to anyone other than the intended recipient. He is casting directly to Zethan.
“Meet me in the glass house at eight, when everyone is at the feast.”
Zethan’s heart skips a beat, and the hairs on the back of his neck stand on end. His breath is taken away with desire, his mouth suddenly becoming dry. Excitement washes over him like a wave, and, suddenly weak at the knees, he has to move before anyone notices his demeanour and starts to ask questions. It is still a couple of hours until the feast, but Zethan could not be more excited. He now has to somehow muster up a plan to get close to Valerious. Just to be in his presence, to even catch his musky scent, would keep him going for the next couple of hours. There is something even more exciting about knowing that no one else knows they have desires for each other, not even the noblemen standing right beside them. They really have no idea what is going on right under their noses.
Zethan seizes the chance to take the next tray of drinks to the hall. He marches purposefully towards Valerious with the tray. Valerious notices his stride and gets a little nervous. He almost thinks Zethan is going to make a scene in front

of everyone. But he knows him too well; he knows he would never jeopardise their relationship.
He watches in awe, mesmerised by his beauty. The sounds of the great hall seem to dim, and all he can hear is Zethan's footsteps as he paces towards him. His heart pounds as the blood flowing through his veins intensifies, making his resonator glow brighter than normal. He doesn't notice this, as he is too infatuated, but Zethan notices, and a wave of concern crosses his face. The magnetism between them is palpable.
He can't allow anyone to see his resonator surging with power, or they will start to ask questions. He cuts eye contact and starts to walk in the opposite direction, but suddenly the King calls him back. He is standing right next to Valerious. Had he seen the connection between them? Was this the moment they would be called out?
His heart starts to beat rapidly again, but this time out of fear rather than infatuation. This could be it, the end. Did they know? Had they been onto them all this time? All these months in the palace, and they had waited until now to expose them, to humiliate the Prince.
His throat tightens as he walks closer and closer to the King.
"Drinks, lad. At long last. I thought my throat had been cut," the King bellows, before bursting into uncontrollable laughter.
Drenched in relief, he looks at Valerious. They must only be three feet apart, and the tension between them is palpable. Valerious laughs with relief, but suddenly stops when he realises how close they are. Luckily, everyone is still focused on the King, so they fail to notice.
Valerious composes himself and slowly takes a drink from the tray. His fingers brush against Zethan's hand as he lifts the drink. They both stifle a smile, and the glow from the ruby crystal intensifies.
Zethan lets out a gentle, uncontrollable sigh of immense joy before walking past him and over to the next guest.